MOREH NEVUCHIM

Seeing God Through Sight & Insight: The Language of the Divine

Given Tuesday 2 June 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim §1 · Ch 3–4

Sefer: Moreh Nebuchim (The Guide for the Perplexed) — Rambam **Section:** 1 · Chapters 3 & 4 (with introduction to Chapter 5) **Topic:** Temunah & Tavnit · The Three Verbs of Seeing — Sight and Insight **Text:** Sefaria edition (Rabbi Chaim Makbili's modern Hebrew translation from the Arabic)

Recap of the Journey So Far

Stage	Content
Introductions	How to learn the book, purpose, meshalim, seven contradictions
Chapter 1	*Tzelem* & *Demut* — the image and likeness of God = the intellectual faculty; humans are the most similar to God
Chapter 2	Adam did not *gain* intellect from the Etz HaDa'at — he already had it. Before the sin: objective perception (*emet/sheker*). After: subjective perception (*tov/ra*) shaped by desire and culture. The snake's offer was moral sovereignty

A Note on Rambam's Method

These chapters are foundational. Rambam writes in cryptic form — **מגלה טפח ומכסה טפחיים** — *revealing a handbreadth and concealing two.* He reveals something, then conceals even more. We'll see examples of this especially in Chapters 5-7.

PART 1 — Chapter 3: Temunah vs. Tavnit

The Problem Rambam Is Solving

Rambam continues to insist Hashem is incorporeal — **not yet on philosophical grounds** (that comes later), but purely on **textual/linguistic grounds.**

The Troubling Verse (Bamidbar / Beha'alotecha)

After Aharon and Miriam spoke about Moshe, Hashem reprimands them:

פה אל פה אדבר בו ומראה ולא בחידות, **ותמונת ה' יביט** *"Mouth to mouth I speak with him... and he gazes at the form (temunah) of Hashem"*

This seems blatantly corporeal — Moshe "gazes at the form of God."

Why We Can't Just Call It "Intellectual"

The problem is the parallel verse in Va'etchanan (the revelation at Sinai):

כי לא ראיתם **כל תמונה** ביום דבר ה' אליכם בחורב מתוך האש *"You saw no form on the day Hashem spoke to you at Chorev from the fire"*

So far fine. But it continues:

פן תשחיתון ועשיתם פסל **תמונת כל סמל, תבנית** זכר או נקבה, **תבנית** כל בהמה... **תבנית** כל ציפור כנף... **תבנית** כל דגה *"lest you make an idol, the form (temunah) of any symbol, the form (tavnit) of male or...female, the form of any animal, bird, fish..."*

Here temunah and tavnit are used interchangeably, both describing clearly physical things — animals, birds, fish, sculpted images. So *temunah* looks unavoidably physical.

The challenge: If *temunah* is physical, then *u'temunat Hashem yabit* implies a physical God.

Rambam's Solution — They Are NOT Synonyms

חושבים שמשמעות תמונה ותבנית בלשון עברית אחת היא, ואין הדבר כן *"People think temunah and tavnit mean the same thing — this is not so."*

Tavnit — Always Physical

משום שתבנית הוא מונח הגזור מן הבנה *"Tavnit derives from the root בנה (bana) — to build."*

It means structure, form — square, round, triangular, etc. **Always physical.**

Examples (all physical):

Source	Phrase
Terumah	תבנית המשכן — the form of the Mishkan and its vessels
Terumah	בתבניתם אשר אתה מראה בהר — the form shown at the mountain
Va'etchanan	תבנית כל ציפור כנף — the form of birds
Yechezkel	תבנית יד — the form of a hand (in his prophetic vision)
Yechezkel	תבנית האולם — the form of the hall (Beit HaMikdash)

The Conclusion on Tavnit

ולכן אין העברית מחילה כלל את הביטויים האלו על תיאורים הקשורים באלוה *"Therefore Hebrew never applies tavnit to descriptions connected with God."*

Tavnit always means something physical → it is never used in conjunction with the divine in Tanakh.

Temunah — Three Meanings

ואילו תמונה הוא מונח מסופק בעל שלוש משמעויות *"Temunah is a polysemous word with three meanings."*

Meaning 1 — Physical Form (Like Tavnit)

The simple sensory image of something — a chair, a table — objectively there.

> ועשיתם פסל תמונת כל — *"You shall make an idol, the form of anything* כי לא ראיתם כל תמונה — *You"* *saw no form"* (at Sinai)

This is the interchangeable-with-tavnit usage from Va'etchanan.

Meaning 2 — Imagined Physical Form

Something physical, but **existing in the imagination**, not objectively touchable.

From Iyov (Elifaz consoling Iyov, recounting a night vision):

> בשעיפים מחזיונות לילה בנפול תרדמה על אנשים... יעמוד ולא אכיר מראהו, **תמונה לנגד עיני** *In the"* *disquieting visions of the night... it stood, but I could not recognize its appearance — a form (temunah)* *"before my eyes*

Elifaz saw a mysterious spirit with a form **in his dream** — physical, but imaginative, not objective.

Meaning 3 — Pure Intellectual Essence

Something **purely incorporeal** — the true essence apprehended by the intellect.

> ולפי המובן השלישי הזה נאמר אצלו יתעלה תמונה *".In this third sense, temunah is used regarding Hashem"*
>
> ותמונת ה' יביט — מובנו: שאת אמיתת השם ישיג *He gazes at the temunah of Hashem' means: he'"* *".apprehends the truth of God*

What Does the Third Meaning Actually Mean?

From Rambam's own Yesodei HaTorah:

> כלומר שאין שם משל אלא רואה הדבר על בוריו, בלא חידה ובלא משל *There are no allegories — he sees the"* *".matter clearly, without riddle or parable*

Moshe — unlike all other prophets — was able to attain the clearest intellectual understanding of Hashem, without riddles, without constraints, without fear. That's what *u'temunat Hashem yabit* means.

Two Major Questions on Chapter 3

Question 1 — Where Is Tavnit Used With Hashem Outside Tanakh?

Rambam says *tavnit* is never used with the divine **in Tanakh**. But there's a famous case in **Rabbinic literature**.

The Answer: Yishtabach — and more directly, the **Sheva Berachot**:

> ברוך אתה ה'... אשר יצר את האדם **בצלמו, בצלם דמות תבניתו** *Who created man in His image, in the..."* *"image of the likeness of His form (tavnito)*

This is a **major problem.** If *tavnit* always means physical (as Rambam insisted), and the beracha says man was created *b'tzelem demut tavnito* — does that make *tzelem* and *demut* physical too? But we established in Chapters 1-2 that *tzelem* and *demut* are intellectual!

The Resolutions

Option A — Split the beracha: *Tzelem* and *demut* = intellectual; *tavnit* = physical. Highly difficult.

Option B — Abrabanel (the answer we must take):

> *The language of Tanakh is its own; the language of the Sages is its own."* לשון תנ"ך לחוד, לשון חכמים לחוד

In Tanakh, *tavnit* is never used with God. But in the language of Chazal, *tavnit* can connote something spiritual/immaterial. Rambam himself codifies this exact beracha (from the Gemara in Ketubot) — so we can't claim he had a different text. We must say Chazal used *tavnit* differently than Tanakh does.

(Rabbi Kada acknowledged this is uncomfortable, but it's what we have to say. A student noted this seems to push against Rambam — surely Chazal understood Tanakh's terms precisely. Possible responses: Chazal relied on the words appearing alongside tzelem and demut; or possibly there wasn't a sharp temunah/tavnit distinction for them. It remains a genuine difficulty.)

Question 2 — The Contradiction in the Verses About Seeing God

This is a contradiction **even on a corporeal reading:**

- Beha'alotecha: **ותמונת ה' יביט** — Moshe gazes at the form of Hashem
- Ki Tisa: Moshe asks to see Hashem, and Hashem replies **ופני לא יראו** — *"My face shall not be seen"* (you may see My "back," not My "front")

How can Moshe both *gaze at the temunah of Hashem* AND be told *you cannot see My face*?

The Resolution

"You cannot see My face" = an allegory: **אמיתת מציאותו כפי שהיא אינה ניתנת להשגה** — *the true essence of God as it is cannot be apprehended.*

- **Ramchal** (Da'at Tevunot) elaborates: you can only "see My back" — never fully attain understanding of God
- **Rabbi Yehuda HaLevi** (Kuzari): **אילו ידעתיו הייתיו** — *"If I knew Him, I would be Him"* — to fully comprehend God would be to equate yourself with God, which is impossible

So *u'temunat Hashem yabit* means: **Moshe grasped the highest level any human can grasp of the divine** — not the complete essence (the "face"), but the maximum a human can attain (the "back"). Hashem tells Aharon and Miriam: *Moshe has attained this level; you have not — therefore do not speak ill of him.*

Chapter 3 Summary

Word	Meaning(s)	Used with God?
Tavnit	Physical form ONLY (from בנה, to build)	Never in Tanakh
Temunah	(1) Physical form, (2) Imagined physical form, (3) Pure intellectual essence	Yes — in sense (3)

When the Torah says Moshe saw the *temunah* of Hashem, it means the highest **intellectual** apprehension possible for a human — not a physical image, and not the complete comprehension of God's essence

(which is impossible).

PART 2 — Chapter 4: The Three Verbs of Seeing (Sight and Insight)

Why This Chapter Follows

Because Rambam quoted *u'temunat Hashem yabit* in Chapter 3, he now examines the verb **יביט** (yabit — "gazes") and the other verbs of seeing used regarding Hashem.

The Three Verbs

דע ששלושת הביטויים ראה, הבט, וחזה משמשים במובן של ראיית העין, ושלושתם הושאלו להשגת השכל

The three verbs — רָאָה (ra'ah), הִבִּיט (habit), חָזָה (chazah) — all denote physical eye-sight, AND all three are borrowed for intellectual apprehension.

Sight (with the eyes) vs. **Insight** (with the mind/brain).

Verb 1 — רָאָה (Ra'ah) — to see

Physical sight

וירא והנה באר בשדה — *"He saw a well in the field"* (Yaakov — physical seeing)

Intellectual insight

ולבי ראה הרבה חכמה ודעת — *"My heart saw much wisdom and knowledge"* (Shlomo)

How can a *heart* see wisdom? This must be **insight**, not sight.

With the Divine = Insight

Phrase	Meaning
ראיתי את ה' — *"I saw Hashem on the throne"*	Intellectual insight
וירא אליו ה' באלוני ממרא — *Hashem appeared to Avraham*	Insight/vision
וירא אלהים כי טוב — *"God saw it was good"*	God *recognized* it was good
הראני נא את כבודך — *"Show me Your glory"*	Give me deeper insight
ויראו את אלהי ישראל — *"They saw the God of Israel"*	An insight of God

Why Eyes Can't Apply to God

משום שהעיניים אינן משיגות אלא גוף, וגם זה רק מכיוון אחד, ורק חלק מן המקרים שלו *"The eyes apprehend only a body — and only from one angle, only some of its aspects."*

When I see something, I see only its front, only one layer, only certain features (its color, etc.). God has no body and no aspects to see partially. So "God saw" must mean intellectual apprehension.

Saadia Gaon's Remarkable Opposing View

(Laid out here, to be returned to in Chapter 5)

In **Emunot VeDe'ot (Essay 2)**, Saadia Gaon — the **first** authority to insist so sharply that any corporeality of God is heretical — nonetheless holds:

When prophets "see" Hashem, it is a PHYSICAL seeing with their eyes — but not of God Himself. Rather:

> יש לבורא אור בראהו, והראהו לנביאים להיות ראיה להם על כל דברי הנבואה *"The Creator has a light He created, and showed it to the prophets as a sign for all the prophecy they would hear."*

- When a prophet says **ראיתי כבוד ה'** (*"I saw the glory of Hashem"*) → he saw this created light. Makes sense.
- When it says **ראיתי את ה'** (*"I saw Hashem"*) → this is a *hester* (an ellipsis); it means *I saw the Kevod Hashem* — the created light.

Saadia's proof: In Mishpatim, *וירא את אלהי ישראל* (*"they saw the God of Israel"*) is followed by *ומראה כבוד ה' כאש אוכלת* (*"the appearance of the glory of Hashem like a consuming fire"*) — showing that "seeing God" really means seeing the *glory* of God.

On "you may see My back, not My front": Even this created light is overwhelming — other prophets collapse when they see it. Moshe could withstand it but only partially; the full light/image cannot be attained.

Rambam Rejects This

Rambam holds ra'ah with the divine = insight, NOT sight. He will indirectly reference and reject Saadia's view in Chapter 5.

Verb 2 — הִבִּיט (Habit) — to gaze

Physical sight

אל תביט אחריך — *Do not look behind you"* (fleeing Sedom; Lot's wife did look)*"* — ונבט לארץ והנה חושך *We gaze at the earth and behold darkness"* (Yeshayahu)*'*

Intellectual insight

לא הביט אוון ביעקב — *"He did not gaze at iniquity in Yaakov"*

You don't see *iniquity* with the eyes — only with the mind. *(Machloket: Rashi/Ramban say this refers to Hashem; Onkelos/Saadia/Rambam say it refers to Bilam. Either way, the "gazing" is mental, not physical.)*

The Famous Case — והביטו אחרי משה

והביטו אחרי משה עד בואו האהל *"And they would gaze after Moshe until he entered the tent"*

Chazal say this means **insightful gazing** — the people pondered Moshe's actions and words. There are two Midrashic interpretations:

The positive reading: They would watch Moshe with admiration, trying to apprehend his greatness, his wisdom, his level of prophecy.

The painful reading (Yalkut Shimoni): Some spoke badly of Moshe — *"Look how large/wealthy he is! He eats from the Jews, drinks from the Jews — everything he has is from our donations. He ran the Mishkan project; of course he pocketed money!"* When Moshe heard this, he insisted on giving a full public accounting — which is why we have **אלה פקודי המשכן** (a complete reckoning of every donation).

A powerful lesson on transparency for leaders — even Moshe Rabbeinu, the greatest of prophets, was subject to such talk.

With the Divine = Insight

Phrase	Meaning
הבט נא השמימה — *Gaze now at the heavens"* (Avraham, in prophetic vision)	Think heavenward, contemplate the universe
כי ירא מהביט אל האלהים — *He was afraid to gaze at God"* (burning bush)	Afraid to contemplate God too deeply
ותמונת ה' יביט	Moshe's intellectual apprehension
והבט אל עמל לא תוכל — *You cannot look upon wrongdoing"* (Chavakuk)	You cannot perceive wrong and stay silent

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Verb 3 — חָזָה (Chazah) — to perceive

Physical sight

ותחז בציון עינינו — *Our eyes will see Zion('s destruction)"* (Micha — physical)

Intellectual insight

אשר חזה ישעיהו על ירושלים — *"What Yeshayahu envisioned concerning Jerusalem"*
היה דבר ה' אל אברהם במחזה — *"The word of Hashem came to Avraham in a vision"*

With the Divine

ויחזו את האלהים — *They perceived God"* → intellectual insight

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Why These Three Verbs? (The Order)

Rambam explains the gradation, and why he presents them in this order:

Verb	Quality
רָאָה (ra'ah)	Simple, sudden seeing — without focus
הִבִּיט (habit)	To gaze, to stare — more focused
חָזָה (chazah)	Deep, **penetrative** sight — piercing

This is why *chazah* is most often used for intellectual visions — it connotes a piercing, penetrating perception. (Think of eyes that "pierce" you.)

The order makes sense: Even though Rambam came off Chapter 3 having discussed *yabit* (habit), he starts with *ra'ah* because it's the most basic form of seeing, then *habit* (focused gazing), then *chazah* (penetrative sight).

Chapter 4 Summary

All three verbs — **ra'ah, habit, chazah** — can mean physical sight. Tanakh also uses all three for intellectual insight. **Whenever they are used in conjunction with the divine, they denote intellectual seeing (insight), not physical seeing (sight).**

Sight = eyes. Insight = mind. With God, always insight.

PART 3 — Beginning Chapter 5: The Introduction (Aristotle & Caution)

Why Rambam Digresses Here

Because Chapter 4 brought verses about people "seeing" God — *Moshe afraid to gaze at the burning bush*, yet *the elders gazed at God* — Rambam now digresses to explain: **Why was Moshe afraid while the elders were not? What does this reveal?**

This will be developed next week. But first, an introduction.

Rambam's Admiration for Aristotle

This is the first place we see Rambam's great admiration for **Aristotle** (ראש הפילוסופים — "the chief of the philosophers").

> כאשר החל ראש הפילוסופים לחקור ולהביא ראיות לדברים נסתרים מאד, התנצל *When the chief philosopher" began to investigate and bring proofs for very hidden matters, he gave an apology/introduction".*

Aristotle explained: a reader should not ascribe to him **brazenness (chutzpah) or arrogance** for theorizing about such esoteric matters (they had no laboratories or evidence — only theory). Rather, it reflects his **diligence and zeal to attain true beliefs** as far as a human can.

Rambam on Aristotle (from his letters)

- Aristotle reached the **peak of human intellect** — short only of what can be attained through prophecy (implying he was close to the level of prophecy)
- A person should spend most of his philosophical study on Aristotle, not other philosophers
- **Yet** Rambam is unafraid to disagree with Aristotle on major matters throughout the Moreh

The Context of Aristotle's Caution

Aristotle was discussing the **motion of the celestial bodies** (a geocentric model, spheres moving around the earth, the outermost closest to the *Matzui Rishon* — the Prime Mover). He noted a puzzle (more motion observed in closer bodies than further ones) — based on the science of his time, now known to be wrong, but the *principle* stands: approach elusive matters with awe.

Rambam's Parallel Introduction — Tread With Caution

שראוי לאדם שלא יתפרץ לדבר הגדול והנכבד הזה מבלי שיאמן את עצמו במדעים ובדעות, ויתקן את מידותיו היטב" *A person should not burst into this great and exalted matter without first training himself in the sciences and beliefs, and rectifying his character thoroughly".*

The Prerequisites for Studying Theology/Metaphysics

1. Scientific and Logical Training

Master the sciences and know how logic works.

This is why Rambam's **first** work (age ~17) was **Sefer HaHigayon** — a book on logic — written before his commentary on the Mishnah. *Before you can write anything on Torah, you must understand how logic works.*

2. Rectification of Character

ויתקן את מידותיו היטב, ויאמית תאוותיו ודמיונותיו" *Rectify his character thoroughly, and put an end to his desires and fancies".*

The Profound Principle on Character and Truth (from Section 2)

Rambam writes something powerful (shared here though it comes later):

כי כשהאדם מוצא את עצמו... נוטה לתאוות והנאות, או מעדיף רוגז וכעס... הוא יטעה לעולם ויכשל בכל מקום שילך, כי יבקש דעות שיסייעו לו במה שטבעו נוטה אליו

"When a person finds himself inclined toward desires and pleasures, or toward anger — whether inherited or self-trained — he will always err and stumble wherever he goes, because he will seek out theories that support what his nature inclines toward."

A person with corrupted character cannot reach intellectual truth — because they will be intellectually dishonest to comply with their desires.

The Aldous Huxley Illustration

The 20th-century British author Aldous Huxley, a lifelong near-atheist, admitted near the end of his life that he *wanted* there to be no God — to free himself (and his contemporaries) sexually and otherwise. This is precisely Rambam's point: **unrectified character distorts intellectual conclusions.** A person bends their philosophy to fit their desires.

The Method

אל לו לעצור בדעה ראשונה שתעלה בדעתו... אלא יבוש ויעצור ויעמוד עד שתתקדם בדרכה" *He should not stop at the first thought that arises... but be patient, cautious, and advance step by step, with modesty".*

Don't grab the first artificial thought. Be patient. Advance in order. Be humble.

Where This Is Going (Next Week)

The whole point of this introduction: it explains **the difference between Moshe and the elders.**

- **Moshe** was afraid to gaze at the burning bush — *"I'm not ready for this yet"* (proper caution)
- **The elders** gazed at God too early — without proper preparation

Rambam will develop this crucial theme next week in Chapters 5-7, which he describes as **really, really important.**

Tonight's Summary

Chapter 3 — Temunah vs. Tavnit

- **Tavnit** = physical form only (from בנה); never used with God in Tanakh
- **Temunah** = three meanings: (1) physical, (2) imagined physical, (3) pure intellectual essence
- *U'temunat Hashem yabit* = Moshe's highest intellectual apprehension of God — not the complete essence (you cannot see the "face")
- The Sheva Berachot uses *tavnit* with God → resolved by Abrabanel: *lashon Tanakh* and *lashon Chachamim* differ

Chapter 4 — The Three Verbs of Seeing

- **Ra'ah, Habit, Chazah** all mean physical sight AND intellectual insight
- With the divine → always **insight**, never **sight**
- Saadia Gaon disagrees (prophets physically see a created light) — Rambam rejects this
- Gradation: ra'ah (simple) → habit (focused) → chazah (penetrating)

Chapter 5 (Begun) — The Introduction

- Like Aristotle, approach metaphysics with caution
- Prerequisites: (1) scientific and logical training, (2) rectified character
- Corrupted character distorts intellectual truth — you seek theories that justify your desires
- This sets up the contrast between Moshe (cautious) and the elders (premature)

Coming Up Next Week

- **Chapter 5** (continued) — Moshe vs. the elders; who may gaze and when
- **Chapter 6** — Further fundamental concepts
- These chapters (5, 6, 7) are among the most important in this section of the Moreh

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B'Ezrat Hashem

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